

Foundations of Forensic Social Work

Learner guide | SWP-022 | School of Criminal Justice & Forensic Social Work

This guide supports a three-part learning sequence for Foundations of Forensic Social Work. By the end of the course, you should be able to explain social-work roles and ethical responsibilities in justice-related settings.

Practice notice: Apply the law, organisational policy, supervision requirements, and approved referral pathways that govern your setting. This material supports learning and does not replace urgent safeguarding, clinical, or legal procedures.

Learning objectives

- Explain social-work roles and ethical responsibilities in justice-related settings.
- Apply the key ideas from Practice contexts.
- Apply the key ideas from Assessment and intervention.
- Apply the key ideas from Ethics and boundaries.

Course structure

Module	Focus	Suggested study time
1. Practice contexts	courts, corrections, policing, victim services, child protection, and community programmes	10 to 15 minutes
2. Assessment and intervention	psychosocial reports, risk/needs principles, advocacy, and trauma-informed care	10 to 15 minutes
3. Ethics and boundaries	dual roles, confidentiality limits, informed consent, documentation, and cultural humility	10 to 15 minutes

Module 1 Practice contexts

This module focuses on courts, corrections, policing, victim services, child protection, and community programmes. Work through the material with a current practice setting in mind, but remove identifying information from any examples you record.

What to pay attention to

- Courts
- Corrections
- Policing
- Victim services
- Child protection
- Community programmes

Learning sequence

Start by defining the purpose of practice contexts in relation to the course outcome. Notice where professional judgement is needed and where a local procedure must guide the next step.

Examine the practical implications of courts, corrections, policing, victim services, child protection, and community programmes. Separate observations from assumptions, identify strengths as well as concerns, and be clear about information that must be checked with a person, family, colleague, or approved source.

Use a respectful, collaborative approach. Explain your role, seek informed participation where appropriate, and document only information that is relevant, accurate, and necessary for the purpose of the work.

When a concern exceeds your role, supervision, competence, or authority, pause and use the correct escalation route. A prompt referral and a clear handover can protect continuity of support.

Practice reflection

Choose a de-identified practice situation. What information would help you work through practice contexts safely, and what would require consultation or a local policy check?

Module 2 Assessment and intervention

This module focuses on psychosocial reports, risk/needs principles, advocacy, and trauma-informed care. Work through the material with a current practice setting in mind, but remove identifying information from any examples you record.

What to pay attention to

- Psychosocial reports
- Risk/needs principles
- Advocacy
- Trauma-informed care

Learning sequence

Start by defining the purpose of assessment and intervention in relation to the course outcome. Notice where professional judgement is needed and where a local procedure must guide the next step.

Examine the practical implications of psychosocial reports, risk/needs principles, advocacy, and trauma-informed care. Separate observations from assumptions, identify strengths as well as concerns, and be clear about information that must be checked with a person, family, colleague, or approved source.

Use a respectful, collaborative approach. Explain your role, seek informed participation where appropriate, and document only information that is relevant, accurate, and necessary for the purpose of the work.

When a concern exceeds your role, supervision, competence, or authority, pause and use the correct escalation route. A prompt referral and a clear handover can protect continuity of support.

Practice reflection

Choose a de-identified practice situation. What information would help you work through assessment and intervention safely, and what would require consultation or a local policy check?

Module 3 Ethics and boundaries

This module focuses on dual roles, confidentiality limits, informed consent, documentation, and cultural humility. Work through the material with a current practice setting in mind, but remove identifying information from any examples you record.

What to pay attention to

- Dual roles
- Confidentiality limits
- Informed consent
- Documentation
- Cultural humility

Learning sequence

Start by defining the purpose of ethics and boundaries in relation to the course outcome. Notice where professional judgement is needed and where a local procedure must guide the next step.

Examine the practical implications of dual roles, confidentiality limits, informed consent, documentation, and cultural humility. Separate observations from assumptions, identify strengths as well as concerns, and be clear about information that must be checked with a person, family, colleague, or approved source.

Use a respectful, collaborative approach. Explain your role, seek informed participation where appropriate, and document only information that is relevant, accurate, and necessary for the purpose of the work.

When a concern exceeds your role, supervision, competence, or authority, pause and use the correct escalation route. A prompt referral and a clear handover can protect continuity of support.

Practice reflection

Choose a de-identified practice situation. What information would help you work through ethics and boundaries safely, and what would require consultation or a local policy check?

Course activity

Use the accompanying worksheet to apply the course sequence to a short case. Your completed activity should show what you noticed, the action you would take within your role, and what you would escalate or verify locally.

Assessment preparation

- Review the distinction between: roles.
- Review the distinction between: confidentiality limits.
- Review the distinction between: ethics.
- Review the distinction between: trauma-informed practice.

References and local adaptation

- SWEEP Academy Course Content Outlines, production blueprint for this course.
- The current legislation, professional standards, safeguarding procedures, and referral directories for the delivery jurisdiction.
- The learner's employer or placement policy, supervision arrangements, and documentation standards.